SPIRITS

TREND

The growing vocabulary of coffee has fuelled the craft and speciality produce culture. It's not only visible in coffee shops, it has also entered our kitchens, and kindled conversations about grinds, roasts, and brewing techniques. A similar conversation has been taking centrestage with our spirits, whether it's Indian gins, single malt whiskies, feni, or rums—narratives encircle quality of the base spirit, botanicals used, provenance, oak quality, ageing conditions, and more. Interestingly, these two are among the fastest growing craft segments in the world, and their coming together is kindling a new breed of drinks, what I have christened 'coffee-accented tipples'.

QUAFFINATION

Coffee came to India when Baba Budan smuggled a few beans from his pilgrimage in the 17th century, and planted them on a hill, accidentally turning India into a coffee-drinking nation. Quaffine is India's first cold brew coffee liqueur, made with Chikmagalur sourced 100% Arabica coffee. "An introduction to the perfect cup of filter coffee during my travels to Chennai fuelled this movement", shares Olson Pereira, Quaffine's co-founder. And much like that one sip in Chennai, they knew a small sip is enough to leave an impression. "There're similar patterns evident in the consumption of craft spirits and specialty coffees in India. The desire for authenticity, unique flavours, and passionate storytelling have led to the rise of such tipples. It's imperative that spirit-makers too shift from generic to craft coffee that excites contemporary evolving palates". There are unexplored varieties of coffees, brewing styles, sweetness quotients, and then comes the mix of sweet spices, creams, single lots, and limited releases. Clearly, there's a lot more to come.

Price Goa: ₹1,850 (750ml); Mumbai, Thane, Pune: ₹2,850, Delhi: ₹1790, Gurgaon ₹1,800- to ₹2,000, Bangalore: ₹3,170; Internationally, Quaffine is available in Thailand, Kenya and Ghana

HERITAGE IN A BOTTLE

Hansel Vaz is the force behind feni's growing mantel in the country. Cazulo was already producing cashew, coconut, and dukshiri feni. Now the offering is joined by a coconut feni distilled with coffee, called 'Cafe Conserva'. "It's not just another product, but a way of bringing back a fading heritage, and the story of Goa", Vaz claims. He passionately narrates the story of how the Portuguese were shocked to find coffee growing in Goa when they first arrived. Every



THE GROWING VOCABULARY OF COFFEE HAS FUELLED THE CRAFT AND SPECIALITY PRODUCE CULTURE; WITH GREATER **AWARENESS, HIGHER DISPOSABLE INCOMES, AND EXPERIENTIAL DRINKING,** COFFEE-ACCENTED TIPPLES FIT RIGHT IN.

